

DREAMING AGES HISTORY · EPISODE 4

# Ancient Greece

*A Calm Journey Across the Aegean*

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## A BEDTIME COMPANION

Two maps, a timeline from the palaces of Crete to the coming of Rome, the people and places you'll meet in the episode, and a short list of trusted books and museums, for the evenings when you would like to wander a little further.

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# The Greek mainland and the Aegean

*Let's begin with the mountains, the islands and the sea.*




*Ancient sites plotted at their real locations on a modern base map (Natural Earth). Coastlines are modern; some, such as the bay at Troy and the pass at Thermopylae, have changed a great deal since antiquity.*

## AT A GLANCE

- Greece was never one country
- Hundreds of city-states grew up in mountain valleys and on islands and coasts
- They were linked by the sea
- They shared a language, gods and festivals

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# Places you'll visit in the episode

*Ten places from the episode, from Crete to Macedon.*

**Knossos** · The great Minoan palace on Crete, with painted corridors and a central court.

**Mycenae** · The walled citadel of the Bronze Age Greeks, whose palaces fell around 1200 BCE.

**Olympia** · Sanctuary of Zeus, home of the games, traditionally first held in 776 BCE.

**Delphi** · Apollo's sanctuary on the slopes of Mount Parnassus, seat of the oracle.

**Sparta** · The city of the Spartiates, two kings, ephors and the agoge.

**Athens** · The city of Cleisthenes and Pericles, crowned by the Parthenon on its Acropolis.

**Marathon** · The plain where Athenians and Plataeans defeated a Persian force in 490 BCE.

**Thermopylae · Salamis** · The narrow pass and the sea battle of 480 BCE.

**Epidaurus** · Sanctuary of Asclepius, the god of healing, with its great theatre.

**Pella** · Capital of Macedon, birthplace of Alexander.

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TWO THOUSAND YEARS, SLOWLY

# A timeline of the Greek world

*Two thousand years of the Greek world, one quiet step at a time.*

## AT A GLANCE

**508/507 BCE**
Cleisthenes' reforms

**480 · 479 BCE**
Thermopylae and Salamis

**336–323 BCE**
Alexander's reign

**146 BCE**
Roman rule

*Early dates are approximate; "ancient Greece" here runs from the Bronze Age to the Roman conquest.*

| | |
|---|---|
| **c. 1900 BCE** | The first Minoan palaces rise on Crete, Knossos among them. |
| **c. 1600–1100 BCE** | The Mycenaean age; Linear B records an early form of Greek. |
| **c. 1200 BCE** | The Bronze Age palaces collapse, for reasons still debated. |
| **776 BCE** | The first Olympic games, by tradition. |
| **8th c. BCE** | The alphabet is adapted from Phoenician; Homer's epics take shape. |
| **594 BCE** | Solon's reforms at Athens. |
| **508/507 BCE** | Cleisthenes' reforms lay the foundations of Athenian democracy. |
| **499 BCE** | The Ionian Revolt against Persia. |
| **490 BCE** | Marathon. |
| **480 · 479 BCE** | Thermopylae and Salamis; then Plataea and Mycale. |

TWO THOUSAND YEARS, SLOWLY

# A timeline of the Greek world

*The story goes on from here, slowly.*



| | |
|---|---|
| **478 BCE** | The Delian League is formed, later an Athenian empire. |
| **447–432 BCE** | The Parthenon is built. |
| **431–404 BCE** | The Peloponnesian War; plague strikes Athens in 430. |
| **415–413 BCE** | The Sicilian Expedition ends in disaster. |
| **399 BCE** | The trial and death of Socrates. |
| **371 · 338 BCE** | Thebes defeats Sparta at Leuctra; Philip II wins at Chaeronea. |
| **336–323 BCE** | Alexander's reign; he dies in Babylon. |
| **Third century BCE** | Alexandria's Library and Museum flourish; Euclid works there. |
| **212 BCE** | Archimedes dies at Syracuse. |
| **146 BCE** | Rome destroys Corinth; Greece passes under Roman rule. |

# From the Aegean to the Indus

*Now let's step back and see how far the Greek world reached.*




*Approximate extent of Alexander's empire at his death in 323 BCE, simplified from the open historical-basemaps dataset; borders are approximate. Long before, Greek colonies such as Massalia (Marseille), Syracuse and Byzantion had spread around the Mediterranean and the Black Sea.*

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# People you'll meet

*The poets, thinkers and leaders you'll hear about along the way.*

**Homer** · The poet, or tradition of poets, of the Iliad and the Odyssey.

**Solon** · Athenian lawgiver of the early 500s BCE.

**Cleisthenes** · Reformer whose changes of 508/507 BCE began Athenian democracy.

**Leonidas** · Spartan king who fell at Thermopylae in 480 BCE.

**Themistocles** · Athenian who built the fleet that won at Salamis.

**Pericles** · Leading Athenian of the mid-400s, behind the building of the Acropolis.

**Herodotus** · Historian of the Persian Wars.

**Sophocles** · Tragic poet of Athens, beside Aeschylus and Euripides.

**Socrates** · Philosopher of Athens, tried and put to death in 399 BCE.

**Plato · Aristotle** · Plato founded the Academy; his student Aristotle, the Lyceum.

**Alexander the Great** · King of Macedon from 336 BCE; died in Babylon in 323 BCE.

**Archimedes** · Mathematician and engineer of Syracuse; died in 212 BCE.

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WHILE YOU LISTEN

# Things to spot, legend and history

*A few things to listen for, and a note on legend and history.*

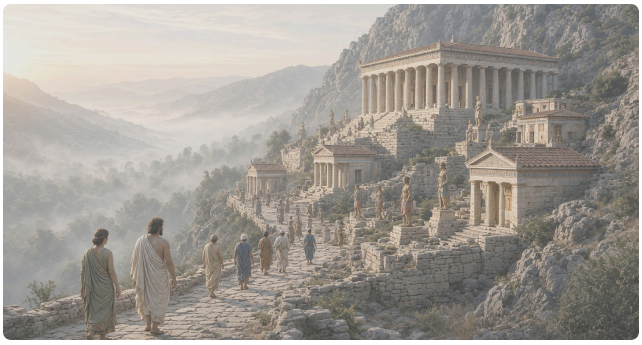
## THINGS TO SPOT IN THE EPISODE

- The painted corridors and central court of Knossos
- Linear B, an early form of Greek
- Apollo's oracle on the slopes of Mount Parnassus
- The Parthenon on the Acropolis
- Archimedes, the mathematician and engineer of Syracuse

## LEGEND OR HISTORY?

Some famous stories sit between myth and history: the Trojan War, Homer as one single poet, and the "three hundred" at Thermopylae (thousands of other Greeks fought there too). The date 776 BCE for the first Olympics is a later tradition. The episode keeps these apart from what the sources and archaeology show.





*Artistic impressions of the court at Knossos and of the sanctuary of Delphi, made for the episode. They are not historical records.*

FOR ANOTHER QUIET EVENING

# Books to read

*If you'd like to wander a little further, here are some trusted places to start.*

*Introducing the Ancient Greeks* ↗, Edith Hall (W. W. Norton, 2015).

*Ancient Greece: A Very Short Introduction* ↗, Paul Cartledge (Oxford University Press, 2011).

*The Hemlock Cup: Socrates, Athens and the Search for the Good Life* ↗, Bettany Hughes (Knopf, 2011).

*The Histories* ↗, Herodotus, trans. Tom Holland (Penguin Classics, 2015).

*The Landmark Thucydides* ↗, ed. Robert B. Strassler (Free Press, 1998).

*The Odyssey* ↗, Homer, trans. Robert Fagles (Penguin).

📚 FIND THESE BOOKS — TAP HERE →

Full reading list ↗

FOR ANOTHER QUIET EVENING

# Museums, places and one last thought

## Museums & places

**Acropolis Museum**, Athens.

**National Archaeological Museum**, Athens: the finds from Mycenae.

**British Museum**, London: the Parthenon sculptures.

**Royal Ontario Museum**, Toronto: the Gallery of Greece.

A BEDTIME QUESTION

*If you could spend one evening in a single place from this companion, would it be Knossos, Delphi or the Acropolis?*

*"Tonight that conversation softens into hush. The oars are shipped. The harbour is still."*

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